

The Price of Greed

Bindu **ruled** over a large and **prosperous** country but he was **greedy** for more territory. He was especially **keen on taking over** a small mountainous kingdom ruled by his brother Ambi. An **astrologer** had told him that Ambi would be **overthrown** by his own **subjects** who would then ask Bindu to be their king.

When this did not happen, Bindu consulted his minister who told him that it was very **unlikely** that such a thing would ever happen as Ambi's **generosity** had made him a very popular ruler.

"Nobody ever goes hungry in his kingdom," said the minister. "Whole families are permanently **camped** outside his palace and he **feeds** them all."

"But how?" asked the king. "From where does he get the money? His country is so poor, his **treasury** must be empty."

"Nobody knows the source of his wealth," said the minister.

Bindu decided to find out. He **disguised** himself as a **beggar** and went to Ambi's country where he **kept watch on** the palace. Early one morning he saw the king **ride out** alone and followed him.

Ambi went deep into the forest and **dismounted** outside a huge cave. Standing outside, he shouted, "I've come."



"Come in and lie in the pan," **bellowed** a voice from inside.

Bindu **tiptoed** to the cave's entrance and **peeped in**. Ambi was lying in a large pan. A rakshas picked up the pan and kept it on the fire. When Ambi had become brown and crisp the rakshas picked him up and began to eat him.

He ate only the **flesh**, keeping the bones carefully by his side. After he had finished, he made a pass over the **pile** of bones, **chanted** a mantra and restored the king to life. The **demon** then **took down** a bag hanging on the wall and emptied its contents at Ambi's feet.

"Your fee for the meal," he said. Bindu's eyes **popped** because the 'fee' was a pile of gold coins. He stole away, **determined** to **lure** the rakshas to his own country and already a plan was forming in his mind.

His enquiries revealed that the king visited the forest once a week. So a week later, he got up early in the morning, **rubbed** a spicy masala which he had prepared the previous night, all over his body and **set out** for the cave. He hoped that the rakshas would find his flesh so tasty that he would be willing to leave Ambi's kingdom and come to his.

When he reached the cave, he shouted, "I'm here!"

"You're early," said the rakshas. "Come in and lie in the pan."

Bindu did as he was **bid** and the rakshas fried him till he was brown and crisp. Then he began eating. As Bindu had hoped, he found the flesh delicious, so delicious, in fact that after he had finished, he took up the bones and began licking and nibbling them till finally nothing was left of the bones.

Ambi had reached the cave by then and when he **called out**, the demon was filled with fear. He had just eaten the man, bones and all, how could he come alive? He felt that Ambi had become more powerful than him. Taking the bag down from the wall he **flung** it at Ambi.

"Never come again," he **pleaded**.

"The bag will give you gold once a week when you shake it. Now go!"

Ambi knew something had happened to **frighten** the rakshas but he did not wait to ask. He took the bag and went.

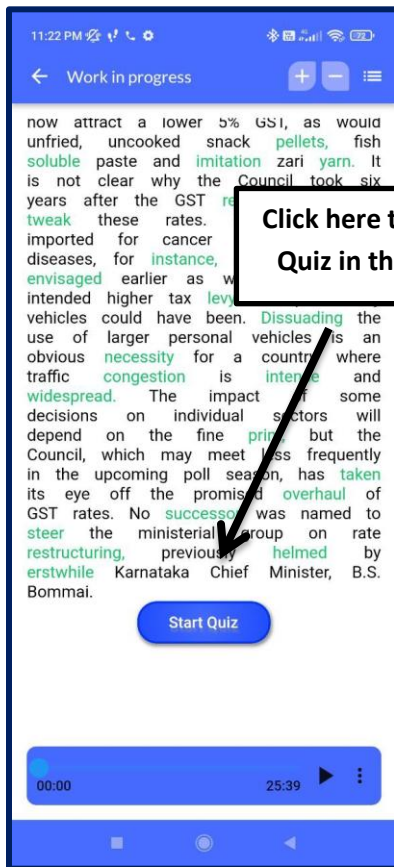
When Bindu did not return for several months his ministers **presumed** that he was dead and as he had left no **heirs** asked Ambi to take over the **throne**. So the two countries united and the country **prospered** under the **benevolent** rule of the **generous** Ambi.

Vocabulary

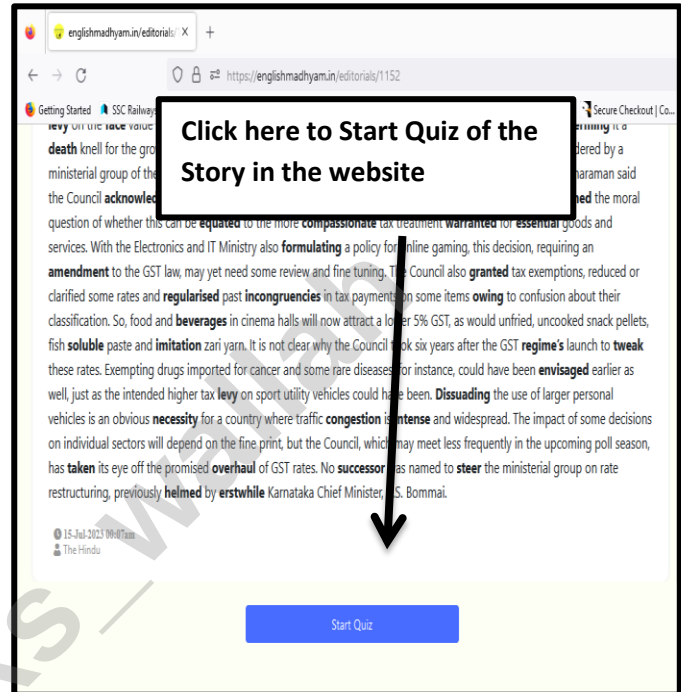
1. **Greed** (noun) – Avarice, covetousness, gluttony, rapacity, insatiability लालच
2. **Rule** (verb) – Govern, command, control, reign, direct शासन करना
3. **Prosperous** (adjective) – Thriving, flourishing, successful, wealthy, affluent समृद्ध
4. **Greedy** (adjective) – Avaricious, covetous, grasping, voracious, selfish लालची
5. **Keen** (on) (verb) – Eager, enthusiastic, interested, desirous, intent उत्सुक होना
6. **Take over** (phrasal verb) – Seize, capture, assume control, annex, acquire कब्जा करना
7. **Astrologer** (noun) – Horoscope reader, stargazer, soothsayer, prophet, fortune teller ज्योतिषी
8. **Overthrow** (verb) – Depose, topple, remove, unseat, oust गिरा देना
9. **Subject** (noun) – Citizen, inhabitant, follower, dependent, constituent प्रजा
10. **Unlikely** (adjective) – Improbable, doubtful, questionable, uncertain, implausible असंभव
11. **Generosity** (noun) – Kindness, liberality, big-heartedness, munificence, charity उदारता
12. **Camp** (verb) – Stay, lodge, encamp, reside temporarily, settle डेरा डालना
13. **Feed** (verb) – Nourish, provide food, sustain, supply, give खाना देना
14. **Treasury** (noun) – Exchequer, coffer, reserve, funds, money chest कोषागार
15. **Disguise** (verb) – Conceal, mask, hide, camouflage, cloak भेष बदलना
16. **Beggar** (noun) – Mendicant, pauper, vagrant, tramp, panhandler भिखारी
17. **Keep watch on** (phrase) – Observe, monitor, spy on, keep an eye on, surveil निगरानी रखना
18. **Ride out** (phrasal verb) – Go forth, travel, set off on horseback, leave riding, venture निकलना
19. **Dismount** (verb) – Get down, alight, descend, step off, get off उतरना
20. **Bellow** (verb) – Roar, shout, yell, holler, bawl जोर से चिल्लाना
21. **Tiptoe** (verb) – Walk quietly, creep, sneak, inch, pad धीरे-धीरे चलना
22. **Peep in** (phrasal verb) – Glance inside, look in, sneak a look, spy, peer अंदर झांकना
23. **Flesh** (noun) – Meat, tissue, muscle, body, skin मांस
24. **Pile** (noun) – Heap, stack, mound, mass, cluster ढेर

25. **Chant** (verb) – Recite, intone, sing, repeat, utter मंत्रोच्चार करना
26. **Demon** (noun) – Monster, fiend, rakshas, evil spirit, ogre राक्षस
27. **Take down** (phrasal verb) – Remove, detach, bring down, unhook, disassemble उतारना
28. **Pop** (verb) – Bulge, protrude, widen, open suddenly, stick out बाहर निकल आना
29. **Determined** (adjective) – Resolute, decided, unwavering, steadfast, firm दृढ़ निश्चयी
30. **Lure** (verb) – Tempt, entice, attract, seduce, coax फुसलाना
31. **Rub** (verb) – Apply, smear, spread, massage, coat मलना
32. **Set out** (phrasal verb) – Begin journey, depart, embark, leave, start निकलना
33. **Bid** (verb) – Order, command, instruct, tell, direct आदेश देना
34. **Call out** (phrasal verb) – Shout, yell, cry out, holler, exclaim पुकारना
35. **Fling** (verb) – Throw, hurl, toss, cast, launch फेंकना
36. **Plead** (verb) – Beg, implore, entreat, beseech, appeal विनती करना
37. **Frighten** (verb) – Scare, terrify, alarm, startle, intimidate डराना
38. **Presume** (verb) – Assume, suppose, believe, guess, conjecture मान लेना
39. **Heir** (noun) – Successor, inheritor, beneficiary, legatee, descendant उत्तराधिकारी
40. **Throne** (noun) – Crown, kingship, royal seat, sovereignty, authority सिंहासन
41. **Prosper** (verb) – Thrive, flourish, succeed, bloom, advance फलना-फूलना
42. **Benevolent** (adjective) – Kind, generous, compassionate, charitable, good-hearted दयालु
43. **Generous** (adjective) – Giving, liberal, big-hearted, magnanimous, unselfish उदार

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